# PSYC 223: Behavior Disorders

***Fall 2026***

M/W/F: 2:45pm – 3:45pm | Location: LH 014

**Instructor:** Richard E. Mattson, Ph.D. | rmattson@binghamton.edu (emails returned within 48 hours) | Phone: 7-5241

**Office Hours:** Clearview Hall, rm 58; M – 12:15-1:15pm; F – 1:30-2:30pm (or by appointment)

**Zoom:** Join instructor Zoom meeting | Meeting ID: 993 8010 0110

### Graduate Teaching Assistant

Hui Qiao

Email: hqiao@binghamton.edu | Office Hours: Science 4 rm 269, T/F – 9:00-10:00am (or by appointment)

Zoom: Join TA Zoom meeting | Meeting ID: 992 5531 0656

### Undergraduate Teaching Assistants

Ayesha Aslam

Email: aaslam@binghamton.edu | Office Hours: (1) Science 4 rm 132, M – 11:30-12:30pm; (2) Join TA Zoom meeting, F – 11:00am-12:00pm

Brooke Gaynor

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Andrew Grzesik

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Sarah Hunt

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Anne Marie Macarchuk

Email: amakarchuk@binghamton.edu | Office Hours: (1) Science 4 rm 132, M – 4:00-5:00pm; (2) Join TA Zoom meeting, F – 1:00-2:00pm

Tomiris Rajabova

Email: trajabova@binghamton.edu | Office Hours: (1) Join TA Zoom meeting, T – 11:30am-12:30pm; (2) Science 4 rm 132, TH – 11:30am-12:30pm

## Course Description and Objectives

This course provides an introduction to behavior disorders and familiarizes students with current issues in their conceptualization and classification, as well as the primary features and characteristics of specific disorders. The course focuses on both the description of various psychological disorders and theories concerning their

development and persistence over time. This material is conveyed through the presentation of scientific findings, clinical examples, and philosophical and sociological topics.

### Course Learning Objectives

By the end of this course, students must be able to:

- Describe and differentiate how behavior disorders are defined and conceptualized by various stakeholders, including clinicians, researchers, and diagnostic systems.
- Differentiate specific behavior disorders by their diagnostic features, course, and associated impairment.
- Apply relevant psychological theory and empirical research to explain the development, maintenance, and treatment of specific disorders from both academic and applied standpoints.
- Critically evaluate constructs, classification systems, and controversies in the study and treatment of psychopathology, including their social and ethical implications.

### Alignment with Departmental Program Learning Outcomes (PLOs)

This course contributes to the Department of Psychology's undergraduate program outcomes as follows:

- *Knowledge Base in Psychology* — Students must demonstrate familiarity with major concepts, diagnostic frameworks, and empirical findings specific to psychopathology.
- *Scientific Inquiry and Critical Thinking* — Students must apply and critically evaluate research evidence and theory bearing on the causes, course, and treatment of behavior disorders.
- *Ethical and Social Responsibility* — Students must engage with the social, cultural, and ethical implications of diagnosis and classification, including stigma and controversy in the field.

### General Education — Wellness (S) Designation

This course carries the University's Wellness (S) General Education designation. Per the University's required Student Learning Outcomes for this category, students must demonstrate knowledge of topics including substance abuse, human sexuality, stress and the characteristics that define physical, mental, and emotional fitness/wellness with a focus on developing a healthy lifestyle. Students must satisfy this outcome through course content and assessment items addressing:

- Substance Use and Addiction — Mechanisms, risk factors, and treatment/harm-reduction approaches.
- Stress, Anxiety, and Coping — The physiology and psychology of stress, and evidence-based relaxation/stress-reduction techniques.
- Human Sexuality — Sexual paraphilias and their clinical/ethical context (topic unit + exam items).
- Emotional and Behavioral Fitness — The diagnostic characteristics distinguishing typical functioning from impairment across mood, eating, and personality disorders, framed around what supports versus undermines psychological wellness.

Material relevant to these content areas will be presented throughout the course and will be directly assessed through embedded exam items and Knowledge Checks administered during class throughout the semester. Individual student work is not submitted for direct assessment—only the sample activity/item and de-identified, aggregate performance data are provided, consistent with University guidance.

## Expectations for Student Conduct & Performance

## Attendance

Students are expected to attend class on time and to remain in the classroom for the duration of the period. Material will be presented that is not covered in the readings, and examination questions will cover this additional material. Attendance is not formally taken, but it will be difficult to succeed in this class without attending regularly. Note that lectures are recorded so that students who miss class for any reason can catch up on missed material. However, Knowledge Checks will be administered in class randomly throughout the semester and will serve as an index of general attendance. You must be present to complete these checks and failure to do so will impact your grade (see Evaluation of Student Performance below).

## Excused Absence & Make-Up Policy

If a missed class does not involve the administration of evaluated work (i.e., exams or Knowledge Checks), then students do not need to make the instructor or TA aware of the absence. Students who miss an exam for any reason — including acute illness — will be placed on a list to complete a single cumulative make-up exam at the end of the semester, administered in a group testing session with all other students who missed an exam for a non-University-sanctioned reason. This exam covers material from all four exams and is not written to be more difficult than the regular exams. If a student misses one exam, the cumulative make-up score replaces that one missed exam score. If a student misses two exams, the cumulative make-up score is doubled. If three or more exams are missed, the instructor will reach out to the student individually to determine the best course of action. Students who were in attendance for all of the exams do not need to take the cumulative final exam.

Only students that have a University-approved "excused absence" will be afforded the opportunity to take a make-up for that particular exam, as opposed to the cumulative final. For student athletes who must attend University-related sporting events, an absence will be excused if they: (a) provide documentation at the outset of the semester and (b) notify the TA ahead of time of which classes they will be missing. Students who miss class due to a religious observance will also be granted an excused absence but only for the time period of that religious event (e.g., students cannot be excused for a week of classes for a one-day religious holiday). Other reasons for absences that are not included above (e.g., family emergency) will be considered on a case-by-case basis, but only for non-emergent situations (e.g., weddings) where the student has provided advanced notice to the TA and documentation of the event.

**IMPORTANT:** Medical problems and emergencies do not qualify as an excused absence! This is unfortunate but aligned with current University policy, which prohibits faculty from requesting documentation for medical absences. Nevertheless, students should not come to class if they are indeed ill or in need of medical attention. The cumulative exam is built into the course in the unfortunate case that a student is unable to make an exam for any reason, including medical ones.

Bonus points for completing Knowledge Checks are awarded based on the overall number completed during the semester and correspond to predetermined ranges (see Evaluation of Student Performance below). This arrangement permits students who have to miss a given class to still obtain the full number of points for Knowledge Checks. However, penalties start to accrue for patterns of absenteeism. Students will not be penalized for missing Knowledge Checks during excused absences.

**IMPORTANT:** University-approved excuses for a missed class cannot be addressed retroactively. Rather, they must accord with the following procedures to be granted: (a) *Notify the graduate TA in advance*: If you anticipate missing an exam for a University-sanctioned reason, email the graduate TA to schedule your make-up as soon as possible, and at least 7 calendar days before the exam if the absence is foreseeable. (b) *Provide documentation*: Ideally this should occur well beforehand, but can be supplied after the absence in special cases.

## Comportment

Students are expected not to engage in conversation or other distracting behaviors during class, or to use direct messaging or other chat functions to communicate with peers during class. This will not be actively policed unless it becomes unduly distracting to the instructor and, thus, a hindrance to the educational experience of other students.

## Libraries

Binghamton University Libraries offers research help, instruction services, one-on-one consultations, digital scanning, resource sharing, and Interlibrary Loans. The Psychology Librarian is Jennifer Embree (Science Library, Rm 107; jembree@binghamton.edu).

## Accommodations for Students with Disabilities

Binghamton University is committed to an inclusive and safe learning environment for all students, including students with disabilities. Services for Students with Disabilities (SSD) determines appropriate accommodations for students who encounter barriers due to disability. Please request accommodation letters early in the semester, or as soon as the SSD process is complete, so there is adequate time to arrange approved accommodations. Accommodations are not retroactive.

**IMPORTANT:**

- Receipt of accommodation letters AND a discussion with the graduate TA must occur at least 48 hours prior to any exam accommodation.
- Accommodations do not specify that exams will be taken in the Testing Center—alternative space complying with accommodations will be provided if needed.
- If accommodations are not discussed with the graduate TA, this will be taken to mean the student does not intend to use them in this class, even if a letter has been received. A confirmation email will be sent by the TA following this discussion.

Students experiencing any disability-related access barrier in this course (printed content, graphics, online materials, classroom seating/location, communication barriers) should contact the instructor and/or SSD right away (SSD website; (607) 777-2686; ssd@binghamton.edu).

## Academic Honesty

All evaluated work submitted for credit must be the student's own work. Students caught engaging in or abetting cheating will not receive credit for that exam, and action will be taken in accordance with the offense and University policy.

## Commitment to a Gender-Affirming Classroom

Everyone has the right to be addressed by the name and pronouns they prefer. Rosters do not provide this information, and no assumptions will be made based on name or self-presentation. Chosen names and pronouns are to be respected at all times and may evolve over the semester.

## Commitment to a Respectful and Safe Learning Space

The classroom is an environment in which students and faculty come together to promote learning and growth. Respect for the rights of others seeking to learn, for the professionalism of the instructor, and for the goals of academic freedom are essential. Neither the instructor, teaching assistants, nor students should be subject to

behavior that is deliberately rude, disruptive, intimidating, or demeaning. Conduct that disrupts the learning process may lead to disciplinary action and/or removal from class.

## Evaluation of Student Performance

Student performance is evaluated by way of four non-cumulative exams, each worth 25% of the final grade (100 points each). Exams may consist of multiple-choice and true/false questions, and each includes optional extra-credit questions that can only help, never hurt, a student's score.

Knowledge Checks will be administered throughout the course at random. The Checks will not be graded but in-class responses will be recorded and used as a means of randomly sampling class attendance. Students with 95% to 100% attendance can earn up to 3 bonus points on their final grade total. Students with 90% to 94.9% attendance will receive 2 points, whereas students in the 80% to 90% range will earn 1 point on their final average. Students with lower than 80% attendance are not provided any additional extra credit. Importantly, Knowledge Checks will resemble exam items, and so difficulty on these within the first two weeks of class should be used by students before the Add/Drop deadline to guide their decision to remain in the course.

**Final grade formula:** $G = ((.25 \times \text{Exam1}) + (.25 \times \text{Exam2}) + (.25 \times \text{Exam3}) + (.25 \times \text{Exam4})) \times 100 +$ Knowledge Check bonus points

Letter grades are assigned using the following rubric. Grade ranges are firm cutoffs (e.g., 92.9% is an A-, not an A, no matter how close it comes to a 93.0%); potential errors in grade calculation will always be reviewed on request.

*Table: Final numeric grade ranges and corresponding letter grades. The header row repeats if the table spans a page break.*

| Grade Range | Letter Grade |
|---|---|
| 100–93% | A |
| 92.9–90% | A- |
| 89.9–86% | B+ |
| 85.9–83% | B |
| 82.9–80% | B- |
| 79.9–76% | C+ |
| 75.9–73% | C |
| 72.9–70% | C- |
| 69.9–65% | D |
| 64.9% or below | F |

## Topic Outline and Required Readings

This is a 4-credit course. In addition to scheduled lectures, students are expected to do at least 9.5 hours of course-related work each week, primarily completing assigned readings and studying for exams. Students are expected to have read case histories prior to the associated lecture content, and to be familiar with all reading materials — including material not discussed directly in class. You may be tested on the readings even when such material was not directly addressed during lecture.

**Required Textbooks**: Oltmanns, T. F., Martin, M. T., & Neale, J. M. (2011). Case Studies in Abnormal Psychology (11th Ed.). John Wiley & Sons. | Craighead, W. E. (2017). Psychopathology: History, Diagnosis, and Empirical Foundations (3rd Ed.). John Wiley & Sons.

Note that the topics and reading list are subject to change, but students will be informed of any such changes as we proceed through the semester.

*Table: Fall 2026 class-by-class topic and reading schedule, listing class number, date, topic, and assigned readings for each session. The header row repeats if the table spans a page break.*

| Class # | Date | Topic | Reading |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Aug – 19 | Introduction, Defining Behavior Disorders | |
| 2 | Aug – 21 | Defining Behavior Disorders | Craighead 1 |
| 3 | Aug – 24 | History of Classification and Diagnosis | |
| 4 | Aug – 26 | History of Classification and Diagnosis | Widiger & Sankis, 2000 (377 – first "paragraph" of 384, last paragraph of 390 – 398) |
| 5 | Aug – 28 | History of Classification and Diagnosis | |
| 6 | Aug – 31 | Introduction to Anxiety Disorders | |
| 7 | Sep – 2 | Introduction to Anxiety Disorders/Specific Phobias | |
| 8 | Sep – 4 | Specific Phobias | |
| 9 | Sep – 8† | Panic | Craighead 3, Oltmanns 7 |
| 10 | Sep – 9 | Panic | |
| 11 | Sep – 14 | Panic | |
| 12 | Sep – 16 | Generalized Anxiety Disorder | Craighead 4 |
| 13 | Sep – 18 | Generalized Anxiety Disorder | |
| 14 | Sep – 23 | **Exam 1** | |
| 15 | Sep – 25 | Generalized Anxiety Disorder | |
| 16 | Sep – 28 | Obsessive Compulsive Disorder | Craighead 5, Oltmanns 8 |
| 17 | Sep – 30 | Obsessive Compulsive Disorder | |
| 18 | Oct – 2 | Social Phobia | Craighead 2 |
| 19 | Oct – 5 | Social Phobia | |
| 20 | Oct – 7 | Depression | Nesse, 2000 |
| 21 | Oct – 9 | Depression | |
| 22 | Oct – 19 | Depression | Oltmanns 6 |
| 23 | Oct – 21 | Depression | Craighead 7 |
| 24 | Oct – 23 | Substance Use and Addiction | Craighead 11 |
| 25 | Oct – 26 | Substance Use and Addiction | |
| 26 | Oct – 28 | **Exam 2** | |
| 27 | Oct – 30 | Substance Use and Addiction | Oltmanns 19 |
| 28 | Nov – 2 | Eating Disorders I | Craighead 12 |
| 29 | Nov – 4 | Eating Disorders I | Craighead 8, Oltmanns 13 |
| 30 | Nov – 6 | Eating Disorders II | Oltmanns 14 |
| 31 | Nov – 9 | Schizophrenia I | Craighead 10 |
| 32 | Nov – 11 | Schizophrenia II | Oltmanns 3 |
| 33 | Nov – 13 | Schizophrenia III | |
| 34 | Nov – 16 | Bipolar Disorder/Hypomania | Oltmanns 5 |
| 35 | Nov – 18 | **Exam 3** | |

| Class # | Date | Topic | Reading |
|---|---|---|---|
| 36 | Nov – 20 | Bipolar Disorder/Hypomania | |
| 37 | Nov – 23 | Posttraumatic Stress Disorder I* | Craighead 6 |
| 38 | Nov – 24† | Posttraumatic Stress Disorder II* | Oltmanns 10 |
| 39 | Nov – 30 | Personality Disorder – Clusters A, B, & C | Oltmanns 20, Craighead 15 |
| 40 | Dec – 2 | Personality Disorder – Clusters A, B, & C (cont.) | Craighead 14 |
| 41 | Dec – 4 | Sexual Paraphilias* | Oltmanns 22 |
| 42 | Dec – 7 | Sexual Paraphilias/Review | |
| 43 | Dec - 14 | **Final Exam – 12:50-2:50pm, LH8(location)** | |

*Indicates a class that contains potentially triggering material. Students who feel that they may experience some degree of distress in response to these topics can decide whether or not they would like to attend. You will be responsible for learning the material from the readings and the power point slides, as well as attending office hours to clarify and material about which you have questions. But not attending the corresponding lectures should not adversely affect your ability to complete the exam.

†Per the university calendar, the Monday, Sept. 7 (Labor Day) meeting is made up on Tuesday, Sept. 8, and the Friday, Nov. 27 meeting (Thanksgiving Break) is made up on Tuesday, Nov. 24.

Note that all of the above dates are subject to change depending on how fast or slow we move through the course material. Students will be notified in advance of any changes.

The Final Exam will be held during Finals Week (Dec. 10–16); the exact date, time, and room will be announced by the Registrar once the final exam schedule is published.